also the vice captain and is an exception in that he's not a tribal but belongs to the scheduled caste community.

"Hockey is the first game kids play here," says Rohidas, who picked up a stick when he was five. "I could barely lift it, but I'd drag it and play." Exploits of his local hero, Dilip Tirkey, who also belongs to Saunamara village, strengthened his resolve to be a professional player. Rohidas trained at the Panposh Hockey Academy in Rourkela, established in 1985. Once home to a limestone quarry, it has a 100-bed hostel, dining area and two astro turf grounds, where both boys and girls are trained. Kalu Charan Choudhury, senior coach of boys at Panposh, whose protégés include Tirkey, Rohidas and Xess, says that of the district's 17 blocks, Balisankara, Rajgangpur, Nuagaon and Kutra are where the passion for hockey is at its peak. "For the first two years, we teach them skills and work on physical fitness and focus on studies," says Choudhury, "By the third year, they begin to play. The state takes care of their stay, equipment, food and fitness."

Sundargarh's contribution to national hockey is not restricted to men. Sharma notes that the phenomenon of girls taking to hockey dates back to the late 1980s, when Panposh started scouting for talented girls after deciding to admit them in 1987. Of women players from the district, former India team captains Jyoti Sunita Kullu and Subhadhra Pradhan, and current player Deep Grace Ekka are some of the many to have represented the Indian flag. Panposh student Jiwan Kishori Toppo, 22, hopes to follow in their footsteps and transition from the junior national team to the senior side. Before that, however, she can't wait to watch her favourite player, Indian mid-fielder Manpreet Singh, at Birsa Munda Hockey Stadium. "You learn a lot more by watching," she says.

BIG STAGE, BIGGER OPPORTUNITIES

Having one of the world's largest hockey stadiums in a belt with 50 per cent tribal population is an emphatic statement. Rohidas hails it as "a great decision". "We haven't seen such a big stadium even abroad," he says. "That it is in Odisha is a matter of great pride." For Odisha, it's a continuation of their long-standing commitment to the sport, one that Patnaik himself played in school—he was a goalkeeper in Doon School. "He understands the emotional chord hockey has in the subconscious of Indians," says Vineel Krishna, commissioner-cum-secretary, Sports & Youth Services Department, Government of Odisha, and special secretary to the CM.

As the golden era of Indian hockey, which had seen it win eight Olympic golds, drew to a close around 1980, the team struggled to make a mark. After years of toil to fully adapt itself to a faster, European style of hockey played by all top teams while retaining the native wizardry of the subcontinental game, Indian hockey's fortune started improving. As the team upped its game, Patnaik stepped up his support in the 2010s. The results arrived in a gush: India won the bronze in the Tokyo Olympics—its first Olympic hockey medal in 41 years—and silver at the 2022 Commonwealth Games. For most fans, a further upgrade, to gold, is due this month.

Patnaik's efforts culminated with

INTERVIEW » DILIP TIRKEY

'The youth are crazy about hockey'

In an exclusive interview to India Today *in Rourkela,* ***Dilip Tirkey****, president, Hockey India, former captain of the national team and three-time Olympian, talks about why Odisha, particularly Sundargarh district, is passionate about hockey, and the state government's initiatives to promote the sport*

Q. What do you think about the Birsa Munda Hockey Stadium in Rourkela?
I have not played in a stadium as massive as this. It's a matter of great pride for our state that India's two best hockey stadiums are in Odisha—Kalinga and Birsa Munda. By gifting these two world-class venues, Chief Minister Naveen Patnaik has worked not just for Indian hockey but also world hockey.

Q. What's in the soil of Sundargarh that so many players have come from this region?
The people here—tribals, the youth—are crazy about hockey. If you go to the villages, there will be some hockey event or practice happening. They don't expect an astro turf; they just want to play for the sheer joy of it. The Khasi Cup is held across villages. If not for the contribution of these organisers, the sport wouldn't be as popular. There was a time when Subhadra Pradhan and me, both from Sundargarh, captained the national teams. The government runs a grassroots programme, which focuses on players' training and development from a young age. In 17 blocks of Sundargarh, 16 synthetic sand astro turfs have been laid out.

Q. Should more states follow Odisha's example and financially support a sport?
All sports and players need support, which in turn, gives them a confidence boost. If you want to develop the sport and improve training programmes, you need funds, and CM Naveen Patnaik understood it. When I go out of Odisha, people talk about the contribution of the state towards hockey. If other states adopt sports, it will make youth want to excel in it.

Q. How do you rank India's chances at the World Cup?
The game has grown so much, there are new styles and techniques emerging every year. Most players from the Olympics